

NORTHERN LIGHTS (Clockwise from far left) Stills from *Aise Hee* (2019), *Dhuin* (2022), *Shoebox* (2021) and *Uljhan* (2021)

years doesn't appear in these reasonably well-funded mainstream productions: the vast scale of unemployment, or widespread misgovernance, or the increasing normalisation of violence along caste and communal lines. Perhaps it is precisely the normalisation of the issues that keeps them nearly invisible—or at worst, turned into cutesy humour (*Dream Girl*, *Gulabo Sitabo*, both 2020).

Some of the effects of North India's misplaced priorities do find place, however, in recent work by a few independent filmmakers, many of them first features. Ashish Pant's *Uljhan* (2021) uses a road accident as the starting point for a haunting exploration of upper-middle-class guilt—and the lack of it. Set in Lucknow, the film navigates the domestic and public sphere, the government office and the fancy restaurant alike, unpeeling the layers of caste and class that make us who we are.

Achal Mishra, who made an internationally feted debut in 2019 with the lovely mood piece *Gamak Ghar*, captures the absurdity and quiet desperation of small-town Bihar in his second feature, *Dhuin* (2022). Set in Darbhanga, *Dhuin* is quietly atmospheric but bleak: an old man prepares a bribe to get a small-time job, young men prepare for scarce government positions while dreaming of Delhi, Bombay, films, escape.

MUCH OF WHAT IS UNFOLDING IN THE NORTH IS BARELY PRESENT IN WELL-FUNDED MAINSTREAM MOVIES

Kislay's delightful 2019 debut, *Aise Hee*, explored Allahabad's stifling social norms through the eyes of a recently widowed older woman whose simple desires make her the subject of gossip and censure: eating an ice cream, befriending a younger woman from a different class, learning to stitch from the local Muslim tailor. Faraz Ali's *Shoebox* (2021), also set in Allahabad, takes an old single-screen theatre as the visual and emotional anchor for a restrained, unsentimental account of social memory and 'development'. Like *Gamak Ghar* and *Dhuin*, *Shoebox* catches a locale stuck in the past, like the young heroine's stubborn father, dragging which into the present means breaking it. Politics is everywhere, as Allahabad turns into Prayagraj, but *Shoebox* chooses to be meditative rather than confrontational. Another 2021 feature debut, Ritesh Sharma's Banaras-set *Jhini Bini Chadariya*, engages more directly with rising anti-Muslim rhetoric in the North Indian street. But here, too, electoral politics is in the background, sometimes only on the audio track.

Most of these films have shown at film festivals at home (Dharamshala, Kerala, Habitat Film Festival in Delhi) and abroad, winning awards (*Shoebox* was Best Film at this year's New York Indian Film Festival). But few have yet got to the OTT platforms that are capacious and fearless enough to promote new voices. One hopes this will change. ■

-Trisha Gupta



ON A LAMPLIT RIVER A shot from *Jhini Bini Chadariya*

theatre background, you've earlier directed two documentaries: *The Holy Wives*, on devadasis, and *Rainbows are Real*, on transgenders....
Yes, both theatre and documentary helped me. My actors are from theatre. Also, you'll notice a lot of long shots. Like in a play, the audience can decide who they want to watch. Also, if you go to close-ups right away, you wouldn't see the space around the characters. You wouldn't see Banaras. I wanted to keep as much reality as I could: Megha Mathur, a theatre actor from Delhi's Shri Ram Centre, spent months with real dancers to play Rani. The dance audiences are real. And Adah is played by Sivan Spector, an actual Israeli tourist I met.

Q. You have only one character who is a politician. But the communalisation of politics is there all around, especially in the track about Shadab, the weaver...
I just shot what was happening in Banaras: rallies, speeches. With Shadab, the idea was to get to those people who say 'I'm not part of the politics, I don't care'. You have to care! ■

- with Trisha Gupta